

UTT Chapter 08 Assignment

Hello there!

I learned a valuable lesson today while I was biking to class; never leave home without an umbrella. As I am sure you can guess, I was caught in a torrential downpour. After the first few minutes, I embraced the flood and attempted to enjoy the remaining ten minutes of my bike ride. By the time I walked into class though, I looked like I had jumped into a lake. I bet it was a pretty funny sight. My Art History professor enjoyed teasing me about tracking water into her class. I have absolutely learned my lesson.

On a positive, and much drier, note, Sarah and Nathan had a really cool idea to start a book club at a local coffee shop near campus. Mark, Paige, and Muhammad joined our discussion too! Today was the first day, and we were supposed to pick out a book. We couldn't really settle on a genre, so the conversation basically turned into a discussion on what each person wanted to read. Sarah wanted to read about the rise of the feminist movement, but Nathan suggested a book on meditation and self-healing. To be honest, I am still a bit confused by what he was saying. I could understand more of it than I did before I read your letter. Thanks again!

Somehow, our conversation shifted towards everyone's belief in the supernatural. Muhammad and I agreed in the existence of God, but Sarah and Mark kept saying it was an irrational conclusion since we can't experience him with our five senses. Nathan was on a completely different planet when he was trying to explain that we are all gods. Paige was pretty quiet, but she did mention something about not conforming to the metanarratives set forth by mainstream religions. I bet this has something to do with her thoughts on Postmodernism.

After about two hours of listening to them—mainly Sarah and Mark versus Nathan—we decided to meet up next week with some specific books in mind. I am not sure what book I will suggest. It is still strange to me that some people don't believe in God or believe we are all god. I know Muhammad and I at least agree that there is only one God, but we seem to part ways after that. He said Christianity believes in three gods. I tried to explain that the Trinity isn't three gods but one. However, I didn't do a very job. Muhammad remains unconvinced.

After I left, I began to think about all they said. Mark calls himself a Marxist, but Sarah says she is a Secularist. It seems like they agree about their theology, but it's hard to wrap my head around how anyone could deny that God exists. **Why do Secularists deny God's existence?** And **why do Marxists deny God's existence?** Also, Paige didn't really speak up too much this time. **How does Postmodernism view God?** Nathan, on the other hand, was calling all of us gods, saying we need to discover the inner divine in all of us. **What is the New Spiritualist view of God?** I'm hoping you can help me figure out how to explain Christian theology to Muhammad. I feel I need to know more about our differences. **What is the difference between the Islamic view of God and the Christian view of God?**

I really appreciate you taking the time to explain all this worldview stuff. It can be quite confusing when all your friends have different beliefs about God.

You are the BEST!

–Doug

Doug brought up five different questions; below is a rough outline of possible responses:

1. Why do Secularists deny God's existence?

Secularism is atheistic by conviction. It believes that science has essentially made the notion of God unbelievable. According to this worldview, science is the only way of knowing what is true. Since we can't scientifically study the supernatural, **atheism** becomes the default position: belief in God is irrelevant to what is important, and this colors Secularism's view of every discipline—geology, biology, anthropology, history, and psychology. [8.2]

2. Why do Marxists deny God's existence?

Marx agreed with Ludwig Feuerbach's theory that God is only a projection of humanity's own making, an *atheistic* belief that says God does not exist. Marx also argued that belief in God was an impediment to science, progress, and economic freedom. Religion was a hindrance set up by the ruling class to suppress the proletariat. When the proletariat believes in God, they delay the advancement of communism. Marx wanted the poor to build a human utopia on earth, not sit idly by praying for divine salvation in heaven. [8.3]

3. How does Postmodernism view God?

Postmodernism, in contradistinction to Secularism and Marxism, is *atheist* by consequence rather than outright conviction. According to Postmodernism, religions are merely socially constructed stories about the nature of reality. Every religion claims to know the truth about reality, but in fact, no single religion has access to universal truth. As Postmodernists see it, **theism** is just a grand lie used to oppress those who subscribe to outdated notions of truth. Postmodernists reject all metanarratives. They reject any worldview that posits a supernatural God and claims to possess truth about the nature of reality. While Postmodernists reject theistic worldviews, those who are consistent reject atheistic worldviews as well. This is why consistent Postmodernists do not claim to be atheists. In practice, Postmodernists are intentionally ambiguous and vague about making grand claims regarding God because they try to avoid making absolute claims about reality altogether. [8.4]

4. What is the New Spiritualist view of God?

New Spiritualists reject both theism and atheism. Instead, they embrace **pantheism**: the belief that everything is god. They often link spirituality and science together by attempting to describe "god" as spiritual energy that permeates the universe. Pantheists ascribe divine characteristics to the energy as the source of all things. The logic follows that if everything is energy and energy is sacred, then we, as energy, are also sacred and divine.

Pantheism is distinct in that it simultaneously rejects materialism and the notion of a personal God, while positing a transcendent divine consciousness that pervades everything. [8.5]

5. What is the difference between the Islamic view of God and the Christian view of God?

Just like Christianity, Islam holds to **monotheism**. Both contend that God exists, he created the world, and that he will one day judge the world. Where Islam differs from Christianity is in the rejection of **Trinitarian monotheism**: the idea that God eternally exists as three distinct persons: Father, Son and Holy Spirit. Consequently, Muslims also reject the idea that Jesus Christ was God. To believe that Christ is divine or that God is triune is heresy in Islam. Where Christianity teaches a Trinitarian monotheism, Muslims consider this doctrine to be blasphemy. Indeed, even Jesus Christ's death on the cross is repugnant to Islam. As Muslims see it, God would have never allowed himself, or one of his prophets, to die such a death.

Despite the claims by Islam, Christianity is unwaveringly monotheistic. It says that God chose to reveal himself through nature and through the Scriptures to show us our depravity and his redemptive plan through Christ's death and resurrection. Through his revelation, we learn God is powerful, self-determining, holy, patient, and loving. He is our judge and also our redeemer. Based on these qualities, we can see that Christians and Muslims have quite obvious differences in their theology. [8.6–8.7]